

Core Rules

How checks work, how combat flows, what your resources are, and how the Rift gives you an edge when you need it most.

Using the Ascendant Guide

Rift Ascendant is a modern supernatural d20 game about Awakened operatives entering impossible Rift spaces, surviving Anomalies, and returning with Essence, Relics, and scars. Use this chapter as the player-facing rules spine before the catalogs.

Core Resolution

When an outcome is uncertain, roll a d20 and add the relevant ability modifier, proficiency bonus if trained, and any situational bonus or penalty. Meet or exceed the DC, Armor Class, or opposed total to succeed.

Rule	Formula or Procedure
Ability modifier	(ability score - 10) / 2, rounded down
Proficient check	d20 + ability modifier + proficiency bonus
Attack roll	d20 + attack ability modifier + proficiency bonus
Save DC	8 + proficiency bonus + casting or technique ability modifier
Critical hit	A natural 20 on an attack doubles damage dice; flat modifiers are not doubled.
Advantage / disadvantage	Roll two d20s and keep the higher or lower result.

Abilities

RA Ability	Use at the Table
STR	Physical force, athletics, heavy weapons, breaking restraints.
AGI	Reflexes, stealth, initiative, finesse weapons, evasion.
VIT	Endurance, hit points, poison, fatigue, bodily resistance.
INT	Analysis, technology, lore, investigation, tactical study.
SENSE	Perception, intuition, anomaly tells, mental resistance.
PRE	Presence, command, social pressure, intimidation, resonance.

Level And Proficiency

Level	Proficiency Bonus	Rift Favor
1-4	+2	3 points, d4
5-8	+3	4 points, d6
9-12	+4	4 points, d6
13-16	+5	5 points, d8
17-20	+6	6 points, d10

Actions In A Round

Turn Element	Use
Action	Attack, cast a spell, use a major technique, activate a Relic, Dash, Disengage, Dodge, Help, Hide, Ready, Search, or Use an Object.
Bonus action	A quick feature, off-hand strike, Rift Favor option, spell, technique, or item that explicitly uses a bonus action.
	A response outside your turn, such as an opportunity attack or a feature triggered by a stated event.
Movement	Move up to your speed, split before and after actions, climb or swim as the terrain allows.
Free interaction	Draw an item, open a door, speak briefly, or perform a similarly minor table action.

Ability Types

TYPE	PRIMARY USE	RESOURCE PATTERN
Techniques	Martial, tactical, weapon, movement, and trained combat maneuvers.	Usually limited by uses per rest, stance, action economy, weapon, or rank.
Powers	Innate Job or awakened authority effects.	Usually scale by level or rank and refresh on short or long rest.
Spells		Use spell slots unless an entry states another cadence.
Runes	Learned or absorbed patterns that unlock abilities or inscriptions.	Follow the rune entry's restrictions, costs, and attunement notes.
Sigils and Tattoos	Permanent or semi-permanent inscriptions with passive or activated benefits.	Follow body-slot, attunement, activation, and recharge limits.

Rift Favor

Rift Favor is the table's heroic pressure valve. It refreshes at the start of each game or when the Warden awards it for dangerous, character-defining play.

OPTION	COST	MINIMUM LEVEL	EFFECT
Rift Boost	1	1	Add the Rift Favor die to one ability check, attack roll, or saving throw before the Warden declares the outcome.
Rift Override	1	1	Reroll a failed d20 and use the new result.
Rift Insight	1	1	Learn one useful combat fact about a visible creature within 60 feet.
Rift Recovery	1	3	As a bonus action, end one condition other than unconscious or dead, or reduce exhaustion by 1.
Death Defiance	2	5	When reduced to 0 HP but not killed outright, drop to 1 HP instead; once per long rest.
Flash Step	1	5	Teleport up to 10 feet as part of movement without provoking opportunity attacks.
Party Link	1	7	Nearby allies cannot be surprised, gain initiative advantage, and may communicate telepathically until your next turn ends.
Critical Surge	2	9	Turn a successful attack into a critical hit; once per long rest.

Rest And Recovery

REST	LENGTH	RECOVERY
Short rest	1 hour	Spend hit dice, refresh short-rest features, and refresh encounter resources that say they return on a short rest.
Long rest	8 hours	Restore hit points, recover spent hit dice as the Warden allows, reset death saves, refresh long-rest and daily resources.
Concentration	Ongoing	A creature can maintain one concentration effect at a time. Damage, incapacitation, or stated disruptions can force it to end.
Death saves	At 0 HP	Three successes stabilize; three failures kill. A natural 20 can return the character to consciousness at the Warden's table standard.

Regents And Gemini

A Regent is a full supernatural authority overlay, not a path. It is unlocked through story milestones or Warden approval and advances alongside the character once gained. Gemini Protocols are rare fusions of two Regent authorities, granting hybrid abilities only when the table has earned that escalation.